

Emotion Wheel

Name it, validate it, reframe it, plan for it, and know when to reach for help · Module 4, Training 5

The wheel

Start in the centre with the closest core emotion, then move outward to the precise word. Precision calms the brain's alarm centre (Lieberman et al., *Psychological Science*).



Identify one emotion (30 XP): Today the closest word is _____. It shows up when _____. In my body it feels like _____.

What the research says about this journey

- Distress in infertility can match that of people facing cancer or heart disease (Domar et al., *Journal of Psychosomatic Obstetrics & Gynecology*).
- Most people adjust well over time; a significant minority develop clinically meaningful anxiety or depression and need support (Verhaak et al., *Human Reproduction Update*).
- Pre-treatment distress did **not** predict treatment outcome (Boivin et al., *BMJ*): your anxiety did not cause a negative test.
- Fertility clinics should screen for distress and refer for counselling (ESHRE guideline, Gameiro et al., *Human Reproduction*).

Tools

Validate: "Of course I feel this." (Of course I'm envious; I want what she has. Of course I'm grieving; I lost something.)

Reframes that hold (true, not pretty): - Delays aren't denials: a month that ends is information, not a verdict. - Both/and: joy for her *and* grief for me, without cancelling either. - This month, not forever. - My body is not a verdict; it's a garden.

Reframes to retire: "Everything happens for a reason." · "Just relax." · "At least you can..."

Partners cope differently: one wants to talk and be held; one wants to plan, fix or go quiet. Say it out loud: "When I'm upset I need you to listen, not fix." / "When I go quiet I'm processing; ask me in an hour." Men's distress on this journey is often unspoken; take the wheel too.

Boundaries are preparation: leaving a baby shower early, muting an account, "we're not discussing that right now" — all allowed.

My coping plan (40 XP)

Emotion (from the wheel)

Trigger (what sets it off)

In my body (where, what)

First tool (sigh · box breathing · walk · journal · gratitude jar · meditation)

Second tool

Who I'll tell, and the sentence I'll use

What I'll say to myself ("Of course I feel this...")

One boundary I'm allowed

If it gets too heavy (who I'll contact)

Example: Envy at a pregnancy announcement · Trigger: the text · Body: hot, tight chest, then heavy · First tool: three sighs before replying · Second: a walk within the hour, permission not to reply until after · Tell: partner tonight — "I'm happy for her and it hurt, both" · Say: "Of course I feel this; her pregnancy takes nothing from me" · Boundary: mute for a week · Too heavy: my counsellor.

When to seek professional help

SIGN

WHAT TO DO

Low mood or anxiety most days for 2+ weeks

Tell your doctor or clinic; ask for a fertility counsellor

Sleep, appetite or concentration falling apart; withdrawing from people you love

Same, sooner

Feeling hopeless, or panic that stops you functioning

Same, this week

Any thoughts of harming yourself

Today: your doctor, a crisis line, or emergency services

Support organisations: RESOLVE (US, resolve.org) · Fertility Network (UK) · your clinic's counselling service · a therapist who lists fertility or perinatal mental health.

Forum support post (20 XP)

Post your emotion and your first tool. Ask for support; that's what the forum is for.

Educational content only, not medical advice. Always consult your doctor or a qualified health professional before changing supplements, diet, exercise or detox practices, especially while trying to conceive.